

KF27 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Try me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Let’s continue practicing **Centering Prayer**.¹

Assume a meditation posture and breathe. *(Pause)* Now, in silent prayer, rest in the spirit and the breath. You might practice the balanced breath using the same amount of time for your inhale as for your exhale. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Ask God for a *word*, and allow that word to surface in your consciousness. *(Pause for 30 seconds)* Stick to this word during the meditation time. When other thoughts hijack your consciousness, gently return to your word. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

For one minute, try recalling the word for one breath and then rest in the stillness for two breaths. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And now, as you are able, practice resting in only the stillness, the quiet mind, for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause, and take a full deep breath, as if you were stretching your insides. *(Pause)* Gently open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting.

You may already know this hymn by the American composer Clara H. Scott. Pray these words with me as I read.

Open my eyes, that I may see
Glimpses of truth Thou hast for me;
Place in my hands the wonderful key
That shall unclasp and set me free.
Silently now I wait for Thee,
Ready my God, Thy will to see,

Open my eyes, illumine me,
Spirit divine!²

Take a deep breath.

(Move immediately to the Karis Confession to allow time for the Toolbox)

0:12 KARIS CONFESSION

0:13 TOOLBOX

This month we are focusing our attention on KF Confession 6:

We chose to foster illusions to save the life of our Idol Self.

When we are living out of misorientation, we foster illusions that fall into two categories: the illusion of our perfections and the illusion of our limitations.

In this world, there is real perfection and there is also the illusion of perfection. Real perfection is a quality that cannot be improved or changed. It is finite and not part of our design or purpose. Rather, it is the perfect arrangement of form, like in mathematics or architecture. In contrast to real perfection, imagined perfection is infinite and continually uses the language of *always, never, more, better, everyone, or everything*. Imagined perfection is never satisfied; it chronically requires more and more effort to achieve its illusions. Imagined perfection is the engine of our discontent.³ It is the illusion that once we have touched perfection, we should always perform at that same standard or, preferably, better. Our real accomplishments and the accomplishments of others are no longer good enough for us. Only better is enough. And if ever we think we have touched perfection, we must use our imagination to ignore the evidence of our actual shortcomings. Although we might enjoy a fleeting moment of satisfaction, directly behind that moment is the gnawing conviction that it could have been, should have been, better. Our happiness is precariously dependent upon our ability to consistently reproduce the perfection that we only briefly touched.

KF members who have seen tremendous improvement in their lives through using the KF tools will sometimes become disenchanted with KF because their accomplishments are not what they imagine they should be. Perhaps they unconsciously imagined an improvement that would support the glory of their Idol Self and became disappointed because they did not achieve it. It's easy to forget that the Idol will always move the target of our expectations and present new perfections to be discontented about. When you seem to be making no progress through your KF work, you might consider whether you are actively, or unconsciously, discouraging yourself by forgetting what you have already accomplished or by judging any achievement as insignificant and petty. By allowing yourself to dismiss what you have gained, you are inviting the jackals of self-hate to take you down.

Just as there is real perfection and the illusion of perfection, there are also real limitations and the illusion of limitations. Real limitations are set by physical laws like gravity and thermodynamics and by physical resources like time, money, health, or mental and emotional strength. These real limitations are all part of the simple restrictions of living in a material world. There are, of course, other real limitations that have to be honored if we are to care for ourselves, build healthy relationships, and develop a supportive community. Furthermore, there are personal and spiritual limitations, as well as limitations of our psyche, all of which, when breached, cause pain and chaos—and it is especially in our search for glory that we

ignore these limitations. The Idol Self fights against all real limitations. It believes that with enough faith or force, it can overcome every limitation without suffering any consequences, and it feels entitled to do so. When, inevitably, the Idol does come face to face with consequences, it has ready-made stories about why those consequences are not the result of personal choices or personal limitations but, rather, caused by outside factors beyond its control. The purpose of these beliefs and stories is to maintain our delusions and save us from hurt pride.

Although our Idol Self refuses to acknowledge real limitations, it carefully fosters imagined limitations—the electric fences and the *No Trespassing* signs of the Idol's taboos. Trespassers will be prosecuted by self-hate. Rather than living within the sane limitations of the Ten Commandments, we burden ourselves with a thousand crazy imagined limitations that stunt our potential.

For decades, I discounted and even denied the value of my small and large accomplishments. My present moment always fell short of my idealized dreams, and I lived in a constant state of disappointment. Imagined possibilities were my only solace, and I worked hard to achieve them. I did not realize that I was working against my design and trying to conform my life to an image that mirrored what I envied in those around me. No wonder I was so miserable! Not only did my efforts drive me to perform contrary to my design, which was exhausting, they also militated against the real gifts and glory that I could offer and enjoy. I had fenced myself in with taboos that restricted and diverted the flow of my design and commandeered my energy to power the wheel of my idealized dreams. I had taboos against self-care, self-development, rest, standing in my own reality, pacing myself in my work, self-knowledge, self-examination, and any kind of self-promotion. For me, it was certainly taboo to recognize and appreciate my real accomplishments.

Taboos are imagined limitations, which, like an electric fence, guard the boundaries of the Idol Self's dreary pasture. The Idol uses these imagined limitations to restrict our choices and stunt our emotional life. Whenever we dare to confront a taboo, the Idol punishes us with the shock of self-hate. For example, when we approach or test a taboo, we might actively sabotage ourselves or simply feel fatigued, irritated, insecure, or anxious. All neurotic types will have plausible stories and feelings that force them back into the Idol's pasture and keep them from exploring any new territory of the True Self.

If you are a mastery type, you will have taboos about giving up or giving in, submitting to limitations, and examining your pride. You will feel strain when you experience the appearance or the actuality of failure, or when you allow someone else to have the attention or the control. Resigned types create taboos about ambition and self-development. So, if you are resigned, you will feel the punishing shock of the electric fence when you see yourself changing, feel your real feelings, or engage with real life. Self-effacing types will feel nearly electrocuted if they do anything out of their own strength and power, make any effort to assert themselves, or take a stand in their own reality. It is important to realize that we all have taboos. The taboos of others may differ from ours, and we may not understand them, but taboos have just as much power in other people's lives as they do in our own.

Think about an area of imagined limitation in your life, a taboo. (*Pause for 5 seconds*) Your taboo is not a real limitation; it is an area of your life where your reactions, feelings, and thoughts hinder your progress and stifle your ability to appreciate your achievement. Perhaps this taboo prevents you from maintaining your new level of freedom.

We will now use the **T-A-T** to explore the taboo that you have identified.⁴ During the pauses, you might like to jot down a few notes or, if you prefer, continue to hold the pose.

The T-A-T

Take the pose by placing your fingers on the three facial points. You might also place the palm of your other hand over the occiput, where your spine meets your skull, and breathe deeply. *(Pause)*

1. **Experience this imagined and self-imposed taboo or limitation. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)* *(Repeat the instruction)* *(Pause for 30 seconds)***

Notice your thoughts, feelings, and physical sensations while you experience your taboo. How uncomfortable is it to approach this electric fence? Breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. Jot down some thoughts and rate how uncomfortable or resistant you feel when you think of breaching this taboo.

Take the pose again and breathe deeply.

2. **Imagine what you would think and feel, and what your life would be like, if you did not have this imagined limitation or taboo. *(Pause for 1 minute)* *(Repeat the instruction)* *(Pause for 1 minute)***

Pause, and if you wish, jot down a few notes.

Take the pose again and breathe deeply.

3. **Listen to the clearing statement: *"God, thank You for healing the origins of this taboo."* *(Pause for 1 minute)* *"The origins of this imagined limitation are healing now."* *(Pause for 1 minute)***

Pause, and if you wish, write.

Take the pose again, and breathe.

4. **Listen to the clearing statement: *"God, thank You for healing all the areas of my life, mind, and body that are misoriented by this imagined limitation."* *(Pause for 1 minute)* *"All the areas of my life, mind, and body that are misoriented by this taboo are healing now."* *(Pause for 1 minute)***

Pause, and write if you wish.

Take the pose again, and breathe.

5. **Listen to the clearing statement: *"God, thank You for healing all the areas of my life that get something out of holding on to this taboo."* *(Pause for 1 minute)* *"All the areas of my life that get something out of holding on to this imagined limitation are healing now."* *(Pause for 1 minute)***

Pause. If you wish, jot down a few thoughts.

Take the pose again and breathe deeply.

6. **Listen to the clearing statement: *"I forgive everyone and everything that I have blamed for creating this taboo, including God and myself."* Breathe and let go. *(Pause for 1 minute)* *"I release everyone***

and everything that I have held responsible for creating this imagined limitation.” (Pause for 1 minute)

Pause, and write if you wish.

Take the pose again, and breathe deeply.

- 7. Listen to the clearing statement: “I ask forgiveness from everyone and everything that I have harmed by holding on to this imagined limitation, including God’s purposes and my True Self.” Breathe. (Pause for 1 minute) “I accept responsibility for the damage that I have caused to anyone or anything by holding on to this taboo.” Breathe. (Pause for 1 minute)**

Pause. If you wish, jot down your thoughts.

Now write down how you feel about this taboo or limitation. On a scale of one to ten, rate the intensity of your feelings or resistance. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Good Shepherd, cut the electric fence of my taboos. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

In our last lesson we talked about the illusions created by appearance, talent, and money. We saw how distracted we are by the ATM, and we learned from James that the only real asset is faith—that is, *action based on oriented beliefs*.⁵ We also considered how the ATM can be used to support illusions of effortless superiority and the *if onlys* of limitless possibilities. For example, we might think, “If only I had enough money, I could stop my body aging.” We are often hoodwinked by the ATM rather than guided by realities.

Many of our perceived limitations are imagined, and in neurosis we carefully foster them in an effort to save the life of our Idol. In chapter 12 of Second Corinthians, we will see how Paul deals with some of his imagined limitations. This passage has encouraged many Christians to revel in, and even be proud of, their weaknesses. Others have used this passage to justify their unwillingness to develop their true potential in Christ. My paraphrase of **Second Corinthians 12:7–10** is based on my own translation and offers alternative insights. Let’s listen to it now.

⁷In order to keep me from raising my True Self up to actualization, and because of the loftiness of those revelations about my potential in Christ, I was given a thorn of judgment and self-hate which spotlights all of my human limitations, real or imagined; a messenger that Satan (or the adversary) used to slap me down, so that I could not raise myself up to the height of my true potential. ⁸Three times I called on the Lord to give me some

encouragement about my limitations so that the pain of self-hate and judgment might be sent away from me.⁹ And the Lord said to me, “My gift of karis relationship is sufficient for you to reach your real potential. Look at it this way. Active energy is matured in frailties. In other words, lack of skill and weaknesses are not to be avoided for fear of self-hate but, rather, to be acknowledged and trained so that your real abilities may have more effect with less effort.”¹⁰ With greatest pleasure, therefore, I have confidence in my real weaknesses rather than in my imagined strengths because the strategic can-do power of Christ that dwells in me is waiting to develop real strength from those weaknesses. Because of Christ’s ability to train me, I have a positive attitude in weakness, in self-hate, in necessities, in persecution, and whenever I am in a tight spot on behalf of Christ. It’s like this: when I feel weak in my Idol Self, at the same time I, in my True Self, am very capable.

Take a deep breath.

Rather than imagining that Satan, the Idol Self, and life events have the power to limit him, Paul takes the position of regarding all life experiments as opportunities to train. He has learned to let go of making his limitations the excuse for remaining in the dreary pasture of his Idol’s comfort zone. He exults in his weaknesses, trusting in Christ’s ability to train him in real skills and a growing God-confidence. Rather than going into self-hate each time an area of weakness is exposed, Paul welcomes weakness as an opportunity to explore and grow. Having a need for training is not a limitation—it is a gift. Paul is eager to courageously explore his weaknesses and to give God the opportunity to help him discover the strengths inherent in his design. In the process of becoming strong, Paul breaks through the electric fence of his imagined limitations and discovers his real limitations. This ongoing discovery strengthens his self-confidence in every area of his life.

All real growth is stressful. I’d like to say that again. All real growth is stressful. You cannot pick up true glory on the bargain table—there are no shortcuts to developing strength and maturity. That’s why very few people are interested in real growth. In order to grow, we must move from the comfortable land of predictable miseries and unsatisfying pleasures and courageously step into the stresses of wandering into the not-knowing with untried skills, but with hope. Through the experiment of navigating this unfamiliar territory, we gain confidence and our faith is strengthened. All the ground that we cover in our explorations becomes familiar territory. Experiments become experience, and life is no longer scary because we now have real, tested skills. The struggle against the internal resistance of imagined limitations can be extremely productive. In that struggle we grow strong; we develop real tested skills that God and everyone else can trust.

If a muscle has plenty of nourishment, it will become stronger when it is worked to the point of exhaustion. Our souls grow in exactly the same way. We sometimes feel that our KF training is exhausting, and the process of wrenching ourselves away from the grip of the Idol’s agenda feels impossible at times. We might lose interest in doing our work, feel lethargic, or want to just forget all about it. But if we have been feeding our souls with Biblical truth, KF tools and teachings, and the fellowship of trustworthy believers, this productive exhaustion of our souls will lead to more strength. When we are exhausted, we can give our souls time to rest by actively enjoying our material experience, self-care, and play. Through both struggle and rest, we develop the strong soul muscles of active trust, glorious hope, and real potential.

Let God, your Trainer, decide when it is time for you to rest and when it is time for you to continue the journey. He will not push you beyond your capabilities, but He is eager to see you grow. When God leads

you to rest, you will be able to thoroughly rest, because you will be really tired—and really proud of your accomplishment. After a little rest, it will be time to build more muscle. If you don't use it, you lose it, both in the physical world and in the spiritual world. As you continually stretch both your internal and external capacities, you grow from strength to strength, from faith to faith, from trust to trust, and from glory to glory. Each time that you are launched into a new challenge, you will begin the journey with more hope and courage than you had in previous challenges. You cannot be perfect and perform perfectly in new challenges because you are an eternally developing creature who is always learning. Perfection is finite, but the karis relationship with God is infinite.

Our prayer might go something like this:

My Divine Trainer, I am more interested in karis with You than in my imagined limitations. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and, if you wish, prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus is: *Consider giving God permission to expose a taboo and to train you beyond that imagined limitation. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider giving God permission to expose a taboo and to train you*, breathe and recognize any feelings or resistance that you may be experiencing. *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness as you *consider giving God permission to expose a taboo and to train you*. Observe your experience. Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider giving God permission to train you beyond an imagined limitation*. You might acknowledge to yourself what sensations are in your body right now. *(Pause)* Observe those sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this taboo and this opportunity to train*. Are you comfortable or uncomfortable? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge exposure and the need for training as good or evil? *(Pause)* What story do

you want to tell about this limitation or taboo? What story do you want to tell about training? *(Pause)*
Observe your responses as just information. You might breathe with a long exhaling breath or with the Dragon Breath.⁶ *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your taboos.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit who stands ready with His spiritual snippers to cut your electric fence .
- Welcome where you are today and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁷

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- In the face of this taboo, I let go of my longing for power and control.
- In the face of this taboo, I let go of my longing for esteem and affection.
- In the face of this taboo, I let go of my longing for security and comfort.
- In the face of this taboo, I let go of my longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are grateful for this opportunity to train and heal. Redirect the flow of our energy toward our potential and toward an authentic life that declares the glory of who You created us to be. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*This is the time in our KF training cycle to consider whether we, as KF members, want to offer the next NHG book study to our wider community. All current members are invited to participate in offering this gift by signing up on the spreadsheet sent with the recent email from admin.

The Romans study begins in mid-October. If you are interested in participating, please register on the website.

(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee year)

¹ www.centeringprayer.com.

² *Open My Eyes that I May See* by Clara H. Scott (1841–1897), www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZJnGxPEv1vU.

³ William Shakespeare, *Richard III* (Act 1, Scene 1).

⁴ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

⁵ James 2:14–28.

⁶ See KF12.

⁷ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.